ALL SET TO RETURN

The exclusive biannual survey predicts a third consecutive term for Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP. But economic issues such as prices and unemployment remain a concern

By **RAJ CHENGAPPA**

There are many qualities that Prime Minister Narendra Modi embodies, supreme confidence being one of them. Another is the astonishing ability to seize the moment and make it his own. As he stood atop the ramparts of the Red Fort to deliver the Independence Day address for the 10th consecutive time this August 15, he presented to the nation an impressive report card of what he and his government have achieved since 2014, encapsulated in a catchy slogan—"Reform, Perform and Transform"—that he is also likely to use in his campaign for the 2024 Lok Sabha election. He then went on to persuasively outline why the next five years were critical in India's march towards a Vikasit Bharat or developed country by 2047, when it celebrates 100 years of Independence. It was in the punchline, however, that the PM's real message lay. "Next time, on August 15, from this very Red Fort, I will present to you the nation's achievements and progress," he said. An audacious assertion from a prime minister at the end of his second consecutive term, a time when anti-incumbency looms as nemesis for even the best of leaders.